

Dinosaurs *through* time

Dinosaurs were an incredibly successful and varied group of animals. They ruled the Earth during the Mesozoic era, from about 252 to 66 million years ago, and spread to all continents. They ranged in size from tiny two-legged meat eaters to long-necked giants that would dwarf any land animal alive today.



Stegosaurus's plates may have been used for display.

The Triassic period

This period opened on a barren landscape in the wake of the Permian-Triassic extinction, which had wiped out more than 90 percent of life on Earth. With little competition, dinosaurs would soon dominate.



Eoraptor

The first dinosaurs

Herrerasaurus and Eoraptor are among the earliest dinosaurs we know about. Both walked on two legs and were discovered in Argentina. Around the same time, the earliest mammals evolved.

Triassic extinction

At the end of the Triassic period, an extinction event eliminated many species, including other reptiles. New dinosaurs emerged in their place.

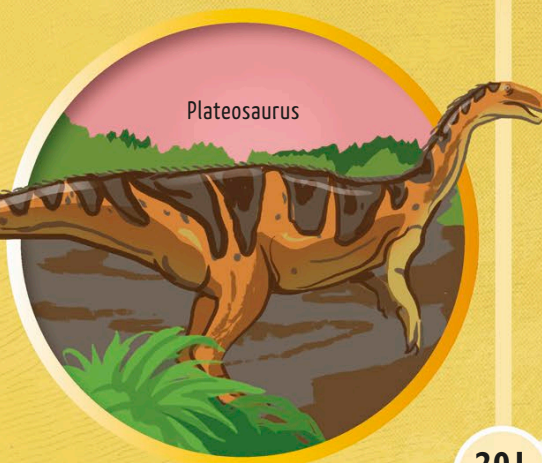


Dinosauromorphs

From the ashes of extinction, a strange group of reptiles emerged. Dinosauromorphs were small, lightly built animals that could walk on both two and four legs. They would evolve into the first dinosaurs.

Getting bigger

Although most were quite small, larger dinosaurs such as Plateosaurus began to emerge. It was around 26 ft (8 m) long.



Plateosaurus

Jurassic giants

As the continents split apart, the climate became wetter, and lush rain forests sprang up. Dinosaurs flourished and large, powerful species emerged, such as Stegosaurus, Allosaurus, and Brachiosaurus.

252
mya

249
mya

235
mya

210
mya

201
mya

200
mya

mya = million years ago